

MASK SLIP

a feature screenplay

Story by Zoe Miller

Screenplay draft - Full Length Revision (Draft 2)

Based on the song "The Mask" by Zoe Miller [zoemcreative](#)
(YouTube)

FADE IN:

*"It was the mask engaged your mind,
And after set your heart to beat,
Not what's behind."*

W.B. YEATS, "The Mask" (1914)

INT. WREN MERCER'S SOUND STUDIO - DAY

A converted garage behind a modest house. Singing bowls, a tuning fork laid on folded cloth, a reel-to-reel tape machine, cushions on a worn rug. Late afternoon light through gauze curtains.

DALE, 50s, a big man folded small into himself, grips his own knees like he's holding himself together by hand.

DALE

I keep hearing her voice. My
wife. Telling me I imagined the
whole thing. That I'm the
difficult one.

Across from him, WREN MERCER, early 30s, sits perfectly still, reading him the way other people read weather.

WREN

You don't have to perform "fine"
in here. That's the one place
you're allowed to skip.

Wren doesn't flinch, doesn't soothe too fast. She strikes the tuning fork against her palm, holds it near Dale's sternum. He exhales: a long, ragged, involuntary sound.

DALE

Is it wrong that some nights I
miss her anyway?

WREN

No. Missing the mask doesn't mean
you were wrong about what was
under it.

A beat. Wren's phone, face-down on the side table, buzzes once. She doesn't look at it. Not yet.

Dale gathers his coat, steadier than he arrived, and pauses at the door.

DALE

(CONT'D)

Same time next week?

WREN

Same time next week.

He goes. Wren sits alone a moment in the emptied room, then turns the phone over at last. A text, not a call: IVY - 2 missed calls yesterday. She frowns, thumbs a reply ("sorry, been slammed, call you this wknd?") and sends it without much weight behind it, one more small, ordinary postponement in a life full of them.

She writes up her notes on Dale, files the card, and starts prepping the room for the next client. An ordinary Tuesday, closing back over itself.

INT. WREN'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - NIGHT

Small, warm, cluttered with dried herbs, cassette tapes, a wall of hand-annotated index cards, a therapist's private taxonomy of red flags. Wren microwaves leftovers, finally checks her phone.

One voicemail. IVY MERCER - Missed Call (3).

She hesitates a half-second too long before pressing play.

IVY (V.O.)
(distorted, phone
pressed too close to
her mouth, whispering
fast)

Wren - okay, don't - don't call
the house line, okay? Just. I
need you to know I'm fine.
Everyone here is so - it's the
realist thing I've ever - Rafe
says once you see it you can't
unsee it and I SEE it now, Wren,
I finally see -

A door SLAMS somewhere on Ivy's end. Ivy's voice drops to
nothing.

IVY (V.O.) (CONT'D)
I have to go. Don't come here. I
mean it. Don't -

The message cuts off mid-word.

Wren stares at the phone. Presses play again. And again.
On the third listen she's writing on an index card without
looking down at it, muscle memory: LOVE-BOMB LANGUAGE,
THEN ISOLATION DIRECTIVE, THEN ABRUPT CUTOFF.

Under the card, dozens more in the same hand. One, older,
more worn than the rest, reads only: DEREK.

She sets the fork down. Picks it up. Sets it down again.

WREN
Not your circus anymore.

She doesn't believe herself. She opens her laptop.

INT. WREN'S APARTMENT - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Search bar. She types: AURELIA CIRCLE. Hits enter.

Glossy results bloom: a retreat center upstate, honey-lit
photography, a logo of a sun wearing a crescent-moon mask.

"RADICAL AUTHENTICITY. COMMUNAL AWAKENING." A man's face, symmetrical, warm-eyed, magnetic: RAFFA AURELIO, Founder. Beside him, poised and serene: SELAH AURELIO, Co-Founder, Keeper of the Circle.

Wren scrolls faster. Testimonials. A "Before/After" gallery of members' faces, glowing.

She stops on one photo. A group shot. In the back row, smiling too hard, eyes not matching the smile: Ivy.

Wren closes the laptop like it bit her.

FLASH CUT - MEMORY (2 SECONDS): A man's hand closing gently, then not gently, around her wrist. Gone before we can hold it.

Wren is breathing like she just ran somewhere.

WREN (CONT'D)
(quiet)

No.

She picks up her keys. Puts them down. Picks them up again.

INT. NAN CASSIDY'S COTTAGE - DAY

A weathered house at the edge of town, garden gone half-wild with medicinal plants growing in defiant rows. Windchimes made of old keys.

NAN CASSIDY, 70s, sharp-eyed, moves like someone who has buried more than she's planted. Books line every wall: psychology, folklore, theology, side by side without apology. She pours tea without asking if Wren wants any.

NAN
You look like you already know
what I'm going to say.

WREN
Say it anyway. I want to hear you
be wrong.

NAN

The Aurelia Circle. I've had four families through that door this year alone, all asking the same question you're not asking yet.

WREN

Which is?

NAN

Whether their daughter is still in there, under it.

Wren sets her cup down harder than she means to.

WREN

Ivy called. She's - it's the same script, Nan. Word for word. "Once you see it you can't unsee it." That's not her language. Somebody gave her that line.

NAN

Rafe Aurelio gives everyone that line. It's the hook before the isolation.

She pulls a fat, hand-bound folder from a shelf: decades of newspaper clippings, handwritten notes, sketches of masks, and, clipped in beside them, a yellowed academic offprint.

NAN (CONT'D)

Thirty years of this. Not just him. It's older than him. Every generation, it finds a mouth to speak through. Grandiose ones, you can spot in a room, all preen and thunder. It's the covert ones that gut you, because they wear grief like a virtue. And there's a third kind nobody warns you about -

WREN

Communal.

Nan looks at her, surprised, then not surprised at all.

NAN

You've been doing your homework.

WREN

I had a professor. Four years,
unpaid tuition, taught in a
two-bedroom apartment.

NAN

Derek.

Wren doesn't answer. That's answer enough.

NAN (CONT'D)

The communal ones don't need one
victim, love. They need a
congregation. They build a
pedestal and call it "community,"
and every soul that claps for
them becomes a small flying
monkey, whether they meant to or
not.

She taps the academic offprint, a 1968 paper, stapled,
brittle at the corners.

NAN (CONT'D)

A man named Dr. Okafor spent a summer at the old Vesper compound, the Aurelias' grandfather's outfit, and wrote this. His conclusion, near as I can translate it out of the jargon: no ghosts required. Just an unusual density of what your books now call the Dark Triad, maybe the Tetrad if you count the cruelty for its own sake, all feeding off ordinary group psychology the way mold feeds off a damp wall. Nothing supernatural. Just math, if enough hungry people find each other and enough lonely people let them in.

WREN

Do you believe that?

NAN

(a long, honest beat)

I don't know anymore. I used to be certain it was an attachment: a dark entity, if you want the older word, that moves house every generation and wears whoever it moves into like a coat. Forty years on, I've stopped needing the answer to know what to do about it. Maybe that's wisdom. Maybe it's just tired.

WREN

That's not exactly reassuring going in blind.

NAN

I'm not going to hand you a spell that fixes it, Wren, because I don't have one. I tried three different approaches on the version of this that took my daughter. Confrontation. Removal. Silence. None of them worked, or they worked and I've spent thirty years unable to tell the difference between working and simply losing more slowly.

Nan opens the folder to a hand-drawn sigil: a mask with no eyes, cracked down the middle like something trying to get out. Beside it, in faded ink: MY ROSALIND. 1994.

WREN

Who's Rosalind?

NAN

(a long beat)

My daughter. She went in to save a friend. She came out wearing someone else's face for the rest of her life. I buried her eleven years ago and I still don't know which version of her I lost first: the one before, or the one they built. And I still don't know, Wren, whether what took her was a thing with a name, or just a very ordinary kind of evil with excellent branding. I've made a strange peace with not knowing. You may have to as well.

Silence. Wren reaches over, closes her hand over Nan's.

NAN (CONT'D)

I can tell you what I've seen
work, a little, at the edges.
Fear feeds it. Shame feeds it. An
audience feeds it, whatever "it"
turns out to be. Refuse all three
and something changes. I don't
promise you it's enough. I
promise you it's the only thing
I've ever seen even dent it.

NAN (CONT'D)

And don't you dare go in hoping
to save the man wearing it.
That's not how this ends, if it
ends at all. It doesn't care
whether he earns his way free of
it. It only ever cared whether
the room kept watching. The day
it doesn't, it leaves; not cured,
not sorry, just hollowed out,
already looking for a fuller
room. Don't mistake that for a
happy ending, Wren. It's just the
only ending I've ever seen.

She presses a small object into Wren's palm: an antique
mirror pendant, its glass cloudy with age, a hairline
crack across the center.

NAN (CONT'D)

It shows you what's real when
everything else is telling you to
doubt your own eyes. It won't
protect you. It'll just make sure
you can't be gaslit out of what
you already know.

WREN

I'm not her, Nan. I'm not
Rosalind.

NAN

No. You've already survived one.
That's not nothing. That might be
everything. It might also not be
enough. I'd rather you walk in
scared and clear-eyed than brave
and certain. Certain is how
Rosalind walked in.

CUT TO:

INT. WREN'S CAR - DAY

Wren drives, pendant looped around her rearview mirror,
swinging. Her hand keeps drifting to her own throat, an
old habit from an old wound. She catches herself doing it.
Stops.

She turns the radio on. Off. On again. Settles on silence.

A road sign: AURELIA VALLEY, 12 MILES. WELCOME HOME.

WREN

"Welcome home." Cute.

She drives on anyway.

INT. HOLLOW CREEK - ROADSIDE DINER - DAY

Wren stops for gas and coffee. A muted TV over the counter
runs a local morning show: RAFE, warm, articulate,
mid-interview, the chyron reading THE MAN BEHIND HOLLOW
CREEK'S QUIET RENAISSANCE.

The WAITRESS, 60s, follows Wren's eyeline to the screen
without being asked.

WAITRESS

Everybody watches that segment
twice. Once for him, once to see
if their cousin's in the crowd
shot.

WREN

You know people who've gone up there.

WAITRESS

(pouring coffee, not quite meeting her eyes)

My sister's boy did a summer. Came back calmer. Softer, even. Doesn't call as much as he used to, but he's calmer. I choose to call that a fair trade most days.

At a corner booth, an older man, HAL, doesn't look up from his paper.

HAL

(flat, to no one in particular)

Or you could call it whatever you want and it'd still mean the same thing.

WAITRESS

(a warning, practiced, worn smooth from repetition)

Hal.

HAL

I'm not saying anything. I'm just not watching the segment twice.

He goes back to his paper. Nobody else at the counter engages him. Wren clocks that too, not hostility toward the Circle exactly, just a town that has collectively decided which questions are worth the social cost of asking out loud.

She leaves a large tip. Says nothing else. Gets back in the car with one more data point she didn't come here looking for: whatever's up that road, the town below it has already made its peace with not looking too closely.

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - GATES - DUSK

Wrought iron gates, ornate, twin carved masks set into the stonework, one laughing, one weeping, both eyeless. A discreet sign: THE AURELIA CIRCLE - RADICAL AUTHENTICITY.

Wren's car idles at the threshold. The gates swing open before she even presses the intercom, as if they'd been waiting.

WREN (CONT'D)

Here we go.

She drives through. The gates close behind her, unhurried, final.

FADE TO:

MASK SLIP

END OF ACT ONE

ACT TWO

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - MAIN HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

A converted manor, warm-lit, string lights strung between old oaks. Beautiful people in loose linen move across the lawn like they're all extras in someone's dream of themselves. It is, unmistakably, gorgeous. That's the trap.

RAFE AURELIO, 40s, is already walking toward Wren's car before she's cut the engine, arms open like he's been missing her his whole life.

RAFE

Wren Mercer. Look at you. Ivy said you had a light on you, but she undersold it.

WREN

(getting out, guarded)
You knew I was coming.

RAFE

The Circle always knows who's arriving before they know it themselves. That's not a trick. That's just what happens when a room stops lying to itself.

Beside him, SELAH AURELIO, 40s, effortlessly serene, takes both of Wren's hands in hers like a benediction.

SELAH

We've heard so much about you.
Ivy talks about her sister like
you hung the moon and then
apologized for the shadow it
cast.

WREN

That sounds like Ivy being
generous.

SELAH

(a warm, private
laugh)

Oh, we don't do false modesty
here. Only radical honesty.
You'll get used to it. Everyone
does, eventually.

Something in the word "eventually" lands wrong. Wren files
it.

RAFE

Come. Eat. Meet everyone. Your
sister is going to lose her mind.

He puts a hand at the small of Wren's back to guide her
forward. Not aggressive. Not quite innocent either. Wren
steps just enough that the hand falls away naturally, no
confrontation, no opening.

Rafe doesn't miss it. Neither does Selah.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - GUEST QUARTERS - NIGHT

Simple, beautiful room. A welcome basket. A single candle
already lit, as if they knew what time she'd arrive.

A knock. JONAH PRICE, 30s, rumpled in a way the linen
crowd isn't allowed to be, leans in the doorway holding
two mismatched mugs.

JONAH

Contraband. Real coffee. Don't tell the Circle - caffeine's "extractive to your nervous system," apparently, unlike, say, three mandatory gratitude circles a day.

WREN

(taking a mug, wary)

And you are?

JONAH

Jonah. Three years in. Groundskeeper, general skeptic, current holder of the estate's least prestigious mask.

WREN

There's a hierarchy of masks?

JONAH

(quieter, checking the hall)

There's a hierarchy of everything here. You'll see it at dinner. Ranked seating, ranked masks for the Unveiling nights, ranked whose feelings are allowed to take up how much air in a room. It's dressed up as spiritual. It's an org chart with incense.

WREN

And Ivy's rank?

Jonah's face does something complicated.

JONAH

Rising fast. Faster than's healthy. Rafe's taken a - personal interest.

WREN

Meaning what.

JONAH

Meaning I'd get your sister out
of here before she finds out what
"personal interest" costs.

WREN

(measuring him)

Why are you telling me this on
night one. You don't know me.

JONAH

(a beat too long
before answering)

Because somebody should have told
the last three people who walked
through that gate. Nobody did.
I'm bad at a lot of things here.
I'm not going to be bad at this
one too.

It's a good answer, smooth at the edges from use, the kind
of thing said before, to someone, that didn't end the way
he wanted.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - GREAT LAWN - MORNING

A "radical authenticity" orientation circle, maybe twenty
members seated on cushions in a ring. THEO, 30s, and
LUCIA, late 20s, a couple luminous and unguardedly happy,
lead a simple breathing exercise. Lucia has Jonah's exact
laugh. Family resemblance, unmissable.

Wren clocks it. Files it.

THEO

(to the circle, warm,
unforced)

Whoever needs it today -
permission to not be the version
of yourself you performed
yesterday.

The circle murmurs assent, genuine. Twenty faces, unguarded, grateful for permission they didn't know they needed.

Across the circle, MARCUS, 50s, a senior "Keeper" with the stillness of a man who has appointed himself the estate's immune system, watches Wren instead of participating. He doesn't blink much. He's the first person here who hasn't smiled at her once.

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - ORCHARD - DAY (LATER THAT AFTERNOON)

A "trust exercise": members paired off, blindfolded, led by a partner's voice alone through the orchard's uneven ground. Wren is blindfolded. Her guide's voice, close at her ear, is Marcus's.

MARCUS

(quiet, only for her,
pleasant as a blade)

Newcomers who ask questions in
their first week usually stop by
their third. I've watched it
happen forty, fifty times. I find
it's kinder to tell you that
early.

WREN

(blind, exposed,
refusing to let it
show)

Is that a threat or a statistic.

MARCUS

It's an observation. We don't
threaten here. We just notice
patterns. You'll notice I let go
of your hand two trees back, by
the way.

Wren freezes. She's alone in the orchard, blindfolded, with no idea how long she's been walking unguided. Real, physical vulnerability, no ritual theatrics required to produce it.

She rips the blindfold off. Marcus is ten feet away, arms folded, watching, unhurried, already turning to rejoin the group as if nothing happened.

MARCUS (CONT'D)

(over his shoulder,
mild)

There you go. Found your own way.
See how that works.

It is impossible to prove this was anything other than an accident. Wren knows, with total certainty, that it wasn't.

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - BACK DRIVE - LATE AFTERNOON

Commotion, unhurried but total. A member Wren hasn't met, PATRICE, 30s, a duffel bag slung over one shoulder, walks fast toward a car parked at the service gate. Wren, still shaking off the orchard, stops to watch.

Nobody grabs Patrice. Nobody raises a voice. Instead, four members converge on her path from four different directions, arriving at conversational range at almost the same moment, as if choreographed, because it is.

FIRST MEMBER

(warm, immediate)

Patrice! We were just talking
about you at lunch circle. Are
you okay?

SECOND MEMBER

(closing the other
flank, equally warm)

You look upset. Did something
happen? You know you can tell any
of us anything.

Patrice keeps walking. The four keep pace, a soft, mobile perimeter, never touching her, never blocking her outright, just present, on every side, radiating concern indistinguishable from a wall.

PATRICE

(not stopping, voice
tight)

I just need to see my mom. That's
all. I'll be back Sunday.

THIRD MEMBER

(gently,
devastatingly)

Your mom, who told Selah on the
intake call that she "doesn't
believe in supporting your
healing"? That mom?

Patrice falters. Just for a step. The perimeter tightens
by exactly that much.

FOURTH MEMBER

(soft, almost pitying)

We're not stopping you. We would
never stop you. We just love you
enough to ask what you're
actually running from right now,
today, on foot, with a bag,
before circle even ends.

Patrice stops walking. Sets the bag down, not because
anyone touched it: because five minutes of relentless,
weaponized tenderness has done what a locked gate
couldn't.

PATRICE

(smaller now, already
reciting)

I don't know why I'm being like
this. I'm sorry. I don't need to
go anywhere.

FIRST MEMBER

(warm, triumphant,
already walking her
back toward the house)

Nobody's mad. We're just glad
you're safe.

They walk her back inside, arms loosely around her shoulders, four bodies and one absorbed one, indistinguishable now from any other cluster of friends crossing the lawn. The whole event lasted under two minutes and involved no threat either could name to a sheriff.

Wren stands alone at the drive, throat tight, hands not quite steady.

WREN

(to herself, quiet)

Flying monkeys. Right. Of course they're kind about it. That's the whole design.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - KITCHEN GARDEN - DAY

Wren, assigned kitchen duty, shells peas beside PIPER LUND, late 20s, who works with the brisk, unnecessary precision of someone who's been taught that stillness gets noticed and punished.

WREN

You moved my seat away from Rafe at dinner. First night. Before anyone told you to.

PIPER

(not looking up)

I didn't move it away from him. I moved it away from where he was about to sit somebody he's interested in. There's a difference, if you've been here long enough to see it.

WREN

Sounds like you've been here long enough to see it.

PIPER

(a flash of something
unguarded, gone fast)

Six years. I came in at nineteen.
My mother sent me here to "fix my
attitude." Funny how that phrase
always means the same thing,
whichever house says it.

WREN

And did it fix you?

PIPER

(hard again, mask back
on)

I don't know what "me" was
supposed to look like before, to
compare it to. That's the part
nobody outside ever asks about.
Not whether we're happy. Whether
we'd even recognize ourselves if
we weren't.

She stands abruptly, brushing dirt from her knees, the
moment closing like a door she immediately regrets leaving
open a crack.

PIPER (CONT'D)

Selah's watching from the porch.
Smile like I said something
funny.

Wren smiles. It costs her something. So, visibly, does
Piper's.

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - ORCHARD - LATE AFTERNOON

Ivy finds Wren alone for once, no chaperone in earshot,
and for a few unguarded minutes the Circle simply isn't in
the room.

IVY

Remember the treehouse Dad built
that one summer, with the door
that never closed right?

WREN

(surprised into an
actual laugh)

You made me sleep out there for a
week straight so you wouldn't
have to admit you were scared of
it alone.

IVY

I was eight. You were the only
person on earth I trusted not to
make fun of me for it.

WREN

I still wouldn't.

A real, easy silence. This is what the whole fight is
actually for: not a debate to win, just this, two sisters
in an orchard with nothing to perform.

IVY

(quieter, the old
closeness surfacing
without armor)

I miss this. I miss you, actually
you, not the version of you I
built up in my head on the bad
years.

WREN

I miss you too. I should have
said it out loud a long time
before I needed a cult to say it
in.

Ivy leans her head on Wren's shoulder, the way she did as
a child, before any of this: before Rafe, before Derek,
before either of them learned what it costs to be picked
first by the wrong person. For one unrepeatable minute,

they're just sisters in an orchard.

Then, in the distance, a bell, the call to evening circle. Ivy straightens automatically, the old warmth folding itself away, replaced by the pre-edited version of herself she wears for the house.

IVY (CONT'D)
(already someone
slightly different)
We should go in. You'll like
tonight's session. Everyone says
so.

The retreat is instant and total. Wren watches it happen and understands, freshly, exactly what she's fighting to get back.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - LIBRARY - NIGHT

Wren, alone with Jonah, scans shelves of self-published Circle literature, Rafe's face on every cover in six different soft-focus poses.

WREN
How does a groundskeeper end up
in the library at midnight with a
stranger.

JONAH
How does a sound healer end up
driving twelve hours to a
compound she Googled first.

Touche. Wren pulls a thin, older book from a bottom shelf, out of place among the glossy self-help. Hand-bound, brittle. A different founder's name on the spine: E. AURELIO.

WREN
Who's E. Aurelio?

JONAH

(uneasy)

Rafe's grandfather. Founded the original Circle in the fifties. Different name back then. "The Vesper Society." Rafe doesn't like people finding this one.

WREN

Lucia has your laugh.

Jonah goes very still.

JONAH

She's my sister. Came in two years before me, chasing the same thing Theo chases in her, whatever that is. I followed to get her out. Never managed it. Started to wonder, somewhere in year two, whether I even still wanted to.

WREN

Because she looks happy.

JONAH

(raw, for the first time)

She IS happy, Wren. That's the part nobody prepared me for. I came here for a rescue mission and found out the hostage likes it here better than she liked it with me. What does a brother do with that? Break her heart to save her life on a theory I can't prove?

Wren has no clean answer. She doesn't offer one. That itself is a kind of respect.

She flips the old book open. Diagrams of masks. A genealogy chart: founders spanning four generations, each

face slightly altered, slightly worse, like a photocopy of a photocopy. At the bottom of the chart, a symbol repeats beside every name: a hollow, eyeless oval.

WREN

"From the womb to the end of the cycle, it was there."

She reads it aloud without meaning to.

FLASH - the candlelit page breathes for exactly one frame: the hollow-oval symbol at the bottom of the genealogy chart darkens, wet, like ink drawn fresh rather than printed decades ago. Gone before either of them can be sure they saw it.

Jonah goes still in a different way now.

JONAH

You shouldn't read that out loud in this house.

WREN

Why not?

Before he can answer, the door opens. SELAH, unhurried, unsurprised.

SELAH

Reading our history. How thoughtful.

She takes the book gently from Wren's hands, closes it like tucking in a child.

SELAH (CONT'D)

Every family has its embarrassing uncle in the attic. Ours just happens to have written a book. Rafe's evolved so far past his grandfather's ideas, it's almost cruel to keep it on the shelf. But we don't hide our history here. Radical authenticity, remember?

She smiles. It does not reach anywhere near her eyes.

SELAH (CONT'D)

Jonah, don't you have a four a.m. start on the roses?

JONAH

(already backing out)

Right. Roses.

He goes. Wren is alone with Selah now.

SELAH (CONT'D)

(gentle, almost maternal)

I know what it looks like, walking in as a skeptic. I was a skeptic once too, if you can believe it. Then I understood: some of us are built to hold the center so everyone else can fall apart safely. That's not a cult, Wren. That's just love with better boundaries than the world gives us credit for.

WREN

And if someone doesn't want to fall apart in your center?

SELAH

(a small, chilling
smile)

Then we love them until they
remember that they do.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - CIRCLE HALL - NIGHT

A "Radical Honesty" session, thirty members ringed on the floor. RAFE presides, gentle, unhurried, terrifyingly patient.

Before Wren, another member goes first: GEORGE, 60s, retired, hands folded like a man at his own hearing.

RAFE

George. Tell the room what you
told me this morning.

GEORGE

(already tearing up,
already grateful for
the chance)

That I let my son think I loved
my work more than him for thirty
years, because it was easier than
telling him I didn't know how to
love anything up close. I only
just understood that about
myself. Here. This year.

The room murmurs warm, communal approval: real tears answered with real tenderness, the machinery humming along at its most sincere and most effective. Rafe crosses to George, presses two fingers briefly to his forehead.

RAFE

(to the room, radiant)

That's what this room is for.
Nowhere else on earth would have
held that the way we just did.

Nobody in the circle is wrong to be moved. The tears are real. So is what happens next.

Tonight's next subject, chosen without warning: Wren.

RAFE (CONT'D)

Wren. New members carry the most interesting weather. What's the first lie you ever told yourself to survive someone you loved?

Every eye turns. This is a public, gentle-voiced ambush, dressed as intimacy.

WREN

(measured, giving as little as she can while giving something)

That if I got quiet enough, small enough, easy enough - it would stop being my fault that he was unhappy.

RAFE

(soft, drawing her further out, an expert angler)

And who taught you that.

A longer beat. The room leans in, hungry, not unkindly, just hungry.

WREN

Someone I loved for four years. It doesn't matter who.

RAFE

It matters here. Names have weight here. What was his name.

The room's attention is a physical pressure now. Forty faces, warm, patient, waiting for her to break first.

WREN

(holding, just barely)

I came here for my sister. Not
for group processing of my own
history. I'll answer for myself.
I won't hand you his name for the
room to use.

A ripple, not anger, worse: disappointment, communal and
total, aimed at her for withholding.

SELAH

(soft, to the room,
not unkind,
devastating)

It's alright. Not everyone's
ready to be fully seen on their
first week. We'll hold space for
when she is.

The phrase "we'll hold space for when she is" lands like a
held debt. Wren has not escaped the room. She's been given
a due date.

INT. TOWN OF HOLLOW CREEK - SHERIFF'S OFFICE - DAY

A modest small-town office. SHERIFF REYES, 50s, weathered,
more tired than hostile, listens to Wren across a
cluttered desk.

WREN

I'm not asking you to raid the
place. I'm asking someone to open
a file. A woman named Marguerite
hasn't been seen off that
property in over a year. My
sister has a "primary"
designation in a ledger I found
that reads like inventory, not
membership.

REYES

(not unsympathetic,
but closed)

Ma'am, the Circle funds our
volunteer fire department, half
the softball league's uniforms,
and Councilwoman Diaz's last two
ribbon-cuttings. I open a file on
hearsay against the biggest
employer-adjacent donor in this
county, I'm not just wrong, I'm
finished. You got anything
besides a feeling and an old
book?

WREN

I have a symbol that's followed
four generations of missing women
through a ledger with the word
"transferred" instead of "left."

REYES

(a long, weighing
pause; he is not
stupid, and not
entirely comfortable,
but he is also a man
with a pension)

Get me something with a date, a
signature, and a name that isn't
a nickname, and I'll look. Until
then, this conversation didn't
reach my desk. I like my job, and
frankly, ma'am, most of what
you've described happens quiet in
half the families in this town
without anybody calling it a
cult.

Reyes doesn't apologize again. He picks his pen back up
and goes back to paperwork that isn't hers.

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - GARDEN - DAY (MONTAGE, DAYS PASSING)

- Wren attends a "gratitude circle." Members confess small failings; Rafe absolves each one with a touch on the forehead, growing visibly more radiant with each confession, like he's feeding.

- Piper "corrects" Ivy's posture, her laugh, her opinions, gently, constantly, until Ivy starts pre-editing herself mid-sentence.

- Late one night, Wren watches from her window as a masked procession crosses the lawn toward a chapel building she hasn't been shown. She counts the masks: wood, bone, silver... no gold. Rafe isn't among them.

END MONTAGE.

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - TOOL SHED - DAY

Jonah, tense, pulls Wren behind the shed wall, out of sightlines from the main house.

JONAH

The Autumn Unveiling. Eleven days. All nine circles send delegates, cameras, donors, the works. That's when they name the year's new Primary in front of witnesses.

WREN

And if it's her.

JONAH

Then it isn't a private tragedy anymore. It's a consecration, with a program and a guest list. Once that room applauds it, there's no version of getting her out that doesn't look like tearing her away from something everyone just watched her choose.

WREN

Eleven days.

JONAH

Ten, now. It was eleven
yesterday.

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - TREE LINE - NIGHT

Wren, tracking the masked procession from a distance, ducks behind an old oak as a floodlight snaps on above her, motion-triggered, ordinary, the kind any gated property might install. She waits it out in the dark.

Once it dies, she looks up: a small weatherproofed camera housing, bolted into the oak's lowest fork, angled down the exact path the procession just walked. Not hidden. Not advertised either. Simply there, the way infrastructure always is once you finally think to look for it.

She counts three more before she reaches the chapel: one in a hedge, one disguised as a garden lamp, one bolted under the eave of the chapel roof itself. An entire estate, watching its own rituals.

WREN

(under her breath)

Radical authenticity. Very
thoroughly documented.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - CHAPEL - NIGHT

Wren, having followed at a careful distance, peers through a gap in shuttered windows. Inside: the "Unveiling." Members kneel in concentric rings by mask rank around a low stone altar, its surface scored with the hollow-oval symbol, worn smooth at the center like a coin rubbed by a thousand thumbs.

Selah moves the inner ring through a rite: ash drawn across each forehead from a carved bowl, a wooden cup passed hand to hand, sipped, passed on. The chant starts as English and slides, syllable by syllable, into something older, a liturgy nobody in this century wrote.

In the outer ring, a wood-mask member Wren doesn't recognize is guided through the ash and the cup first, younger, newer, still fighting it. Underneath the mask: red-rimmed eyes, a jaw clenched against sobbing, a face still entirely, defiantly present. Selah cups the woman's chin, murmuring something too quiet to hear through the glass. The room hums louder, patient, in no hurry at all.

A member near the center, MARGUERITE, 50s, silver mask, drinks last, longest, from a cup nearly empty by the time it reaches her. She's guided to remove her mask next.

Underneath: her face is slack, present but absent, eyes open and utterly, chillingly still. Dead-eyed. The room murmurs approval, as if this emptiness is the goal, not the cost.

The candle flames along the altar lean, all at once, toward Marguerite, against what should be the draft. Wren blinks. They're upright again. She can't be sure, through old glass, at this distance, whether she saw it or wanted to.

High in the shuttered eave above the altar, the fourth camera she's counted tonight catches the candlelight on its lens. This one, unlike the others, is aimed not at the door. At the mirror hung behind the stone.

Wren's breath fogs the glass. She steps back too fast, knocks a plant pot. It shatters.

Every masked head inside turns at once, in perfect unison, toward the window.

Wren runs.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - GUEST QUARTERS - LATER THAT NIGHT

Wren, breathless, bolts the door. There is no lock, of course there isn't, this is a house built on the idea that no one should need one. She sits with her back against it anyway.

She pulls out Nan's pendant. Holds it up. In its cloudy mirror, her own reflection looks fine. Steady. Real.

She exhales.

A soft knock. It's Ivy.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - GUEST QUARTERS - CONTINUOUS

Ivy slips in, agitated, checking the hall behind her like a woman checking for weather.

IVY

You went to the chapel. Piper saw you.

WREN

Ivy, that woman in there -
Marguerite - her eyes were -

IVY

(fast, defensive, a
rehearsed cadence)
She's integrating. It looks
strange from outside. Everything
transformative looks strange from
outside, that's what outside is
FOR, Wren, it's the place that
doesn't understand yet -

WREN

Do you hear yourself? That's not
your sentence. I've heard that
sentence in this house from three
different mouths tonight.

IVY

(voice cracking, just
for a second, then
catching itself)
Maybe it's true whoever says it.

WREN

Ivy -

IVY

(suddenly hard, a mask
of her own snapping
into place)

You don't get to come here after
four years of barely calling and
tell me my life is wrong. You
left. I found something. Why
can't you just be happy that
someone finally -

She stops herself. Too late. Wren catches it.

WREN

(soft)

Finally what?

IVY

(smaller now, the
crack showing again)

Finally picked me first.

The room goes quiet. That is the whole wound, laid bare
for one unguarded second.

WREN

(gently)

I'm sorry I made you feel like
you came second. I was drowning
too, back then. That doesn't make
it okay. But Ivy - being picked
first by someone who studies
exactly how to make you feel
picked - that's not the same as
being loved.

IVY

(rebuilding the wall
in real time)

You don't know him.

WREN

I know the pattern. I've slept
beside the pattern. It doesn't
care whose face it's wearing.

Ivy's eyes flick to the door. Someone's coming.

IVY

(urgent whisper)

Just - go to the Founders' Dinner
tomorrow. Smile. Don't ask about
the chapel. Please, Wren. For me.

She's gone before Wren can answer.

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - HERB GARDEN - MORNING

Wren finds MARGUERITE, 50s, alone, kneeling in the dirt,
silver mask hanging from her belt now rather than worn,
tending rosemary with slow, careful hands. Up close, in
daylight, she isn't a monster or a warning. She's just a
tired, gentle-looking woman weeding a garden.

WREN

(crouching to her
level, careful,
gentle)

Marguerite. My name's Wren. I saw
you at the Unveiling. I wanted to
check you're okay.

Marguerite doesn't startle. Doesn't look up right away.
When she does, her eyes are calm: not the dead stillness
from the chapel, just an ordinary, weathered calm, which
is somehow more unsettling for being so unremarkable.

MARGUERITE
(pleasant, distant,
like reciting a
well-worn fact about
the weather)

I'm the most okay I've ever been.
People ask me that a lot, the new
ones. You'll stop asking
eventually. Everyone does.

WREN
Do you remember who you were
before you came here?

A long pause. For one fragile second, something flickers
behind Marguerite's calm, not fear, something worse: a
kind of reaching, like a hand pressed against glass from
the wrong side.

MARGUERITE
(the flicker, then
gone)

I remember a name. I don't keep
it anywhere useful anymore. Six
years is a long time to carry two
people at once. It got easier
when I stopped trying.

She goes back to the rosemary, done with the conversation,
not unkindly, simply finished.

MARGUERITE (CONT'D)
(not looking up,
almost an
afterthought)

You have very loud eyes, for
someone new. Rafe will like that
about you for exactly as long as
it takes him to decide he
doesn't.

Wren sits back on her heels, more shaken by this quiet,
contented woman than by anything overtly threatening the
house has shown her yet.

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - MAIN LAWN - DAY (EARLIER THAT AFTERNOON)

Coaches arrive. Members from three other "sister circles" disembark: identical linen, identical warmth, different logos, all variations on a sun and a mask. Banners go up: THE VESPER FAMILY OF CIRCLES - FOUNDED IN TRUTH.

A woman in her forties, from the "Meridian Circle" two states over, greets Selah like an old, beloved colleague.

MERIDIAN LEADER

(warm, genuine,
utterly unbothered)

Forty-one new members since
spring. We tell them all: the
model works because the Aurelias
perfected it first. We just carry
the torch.

Wren does the math in real time: not one man. Nine houses,
nine leaders, each one certain they're the exception who
does it kindly.

JONAH

(quiet, beside her)

There's nine of these now, that I
know of. Rafe doesn't even run
half of them day to day anymore.
He doesn't have to. He just has
to be the story they all tell
about where it started.

WREN

That's not a man. That's a
franchise agreement wearing a
man's face.

JONAH

(grim)

Or the same old hollow thing,
wearing nine houses instead of
one. Take your pick. The
paperwork looks identical either
way.

Later, unloading linens from the coach, the Meridian
Leader catches Wren alone for a moment, her warmth
dropping half a register, not gone, just recalibrated for
a smaller audience.

MERIDIAN LEADER

(quiet, quick, not
looking at Wren
directly)

You're the sister. Ivy's sister.
I raised a concern about a
"primary" transition once, four
years ago, at my own house.
Politely. Once. I was very gently
reminded how much my circle owes
the Aurelia name for its start-up
capital.

WREN

(carefully)

Is that a warning.

MERIDIAN LEADER

(already moving on,
voice back to full
warmth, the door
closing as fast as it
opened)

It's forty-one new members since
spring and a mortgage on a
building I couldn't have afforded
on my own. Make of that whatever
helps you sleep. I know what I
made of it.

She's gone before Wren can press further, back to being exactly as warm and exactly as unbothered as she was thirty seconds ago, the recalibration total and immediate.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - DINING HALL - NEXT DAY

Founders' Dinner. Grander, more members than before, visiting "sister circles" in attendance, the communal reach made visible: banners, a slideshow of press clippings, Councilwoman DIAZ toasting the Circle's "commitment to this community."

Wren, seated near Rafe now (a deliberate elevation, a lure), decides to test the room.

WREN

(evenly, to the table,
pitched to carry)

I saw the Unveiling last night.
Through the chapel window.

The room's warmth doesn't drop all at once. It curdles, gradually, expertly.

RAFE

(a soft, wounded
laugh, playing to the
room)

Everyone. Wren watched a sacred, consensual practice through a window, without context, and has decided to share her interpretation at dinner. I only bring it up because - well, I think it's a beautiful example of exactly what we teach here. The outside world sees ritual and calls it damage, because the outside world was never taught to sit with anything uncomfortable.

Murmurs of sympathetic agreement. Rafe's eyes glisten, genuinely, theatrically hurt.

RAFE (CONT'D)

I've given fifteen years of my life building a place where broken people stop performing "fine." And I understand, truly, I do - it must be frightening, to watch people heal in a way you don't recognize. I'm not angry. I just feel for you.

WREN

(steady, refusing the bait)

That's a very generous way of not answering the question.

SELAH

(smooth, stepping in)

Wren, sweetheart, no one's under attack here except the one person accusing a room full of grieving, hopeful people of something ugly, on her second week. Can you hear how that lands?

THEO

(sincere, hurt on Rafe's behalf)

I owe this man my marriage. Lucia and I were nothing before this room. I don't know what you saw through a window, but I know what I've lived for three years, every day, in daylight. Doesn't that count for something?

It's a heartfelt, true, devastating question, and nobody in the room, including Wren, including us, has a clean answer to it.

COUNCILWOMAN DIAZ
(oblivious, chiming
in)

This community has done more for
this town's mental health than
any clinic in thirty miles. I'd
hate for a misunderstanding to -

RAFE
(magnanimous, cutting
her off gently)
No, no. Let her speak. We don't
silence people here. That's the
whole point.

He's just demonstrated total control of the room while
performing its opposite. Wren clocks it: the reversal
complete, textbook, elegant. She's now the aggressor. The
room believes it entirely.

Piper, across the table, doesn't even bother hiding her
satisfaction. Ivy stares at her plate like it might
swallow her.

Wren says nothing more. There is nothing to say that this
room will hear correctly tonight.

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - GROUNDS - NIGHT

Wren walks alone, rattled, replaying it. Jonah falls into
step beside her.

JONAH
He's got a name for that move.
Deny it happened, attack the one
who noticed, make her the villain
before she's caught her breath.
Down to a metronome.

WREN

I know what it's called. Knowing what it's called doesn't stop it from working on a room of forty people. Theo meant every word of what he said. That's the part I can't file away clean.

JONAH

(quiet, honest)

Yeah. That one keeps me up at night. If it only worked on fools, it'd be easy to hate. It works on people who are, by every other measure, thoughtful and kind. That should scare you more than a monster would.

WREN

Why do you stay, Jonah? You see all of it.

JONAH

(long pause)

Lucia. Same reason you're standing in this garden instead of your car. I keep telling myself I'm gathering evidence. Some days that's true. Some days I think I just like being close to the fire because at least the fire's honest about what it is.

WREN

That's the thing keeping you here talking, not the evidence.

JONAH

(a tired, real laugh)

Probably. Knowing that's never once gotten me to the gate.

She almost smiles. It doesn't quite arrive.

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - FAR EDGE OF THE PROPERTY - NIGHT

Wren, out of range of the house lights, finally gets a phone signal. Calls Nan.

NAN (V.O.)
(through static)
You sound like you haven't slept.

WREN
There's a man named Theo in here who owes this place his marriage and means it. A woman named Doris who's been here ten years and seems, genuinely, better for it. I came in ready to find one kind of monster and I keep finding people I can't sort into "victim" or "fine."

NAN (V.O.)
That's not a flaw in your investigation, Wren. That's what it actually looks like from inside. My Rosalind had good years in there too. Years I'd have called her happy, if you'd stopped the tape at the right minute. Doesn't mean the ending wasn't the ending.

WREN
How do I know which minute I'm in.

NAN (V.O.)
(a tired, honest laugh)
You don't, until the tape runs out. I'm sorry. That's the only true answer I've got left after thirty years of looking for a better one.

WREN

There's a date now, Nan. Ten days. Some ceremony where they name her in front of the other houses.

NAN (V.O.)

(the tiredness gone,
replaced by something
sharper)

Then you don't have thirty years to figure out which minute you're in. You have ten days. Move like it.

The line crackles. Wren looks back at the house, warm and golden against the dark.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - GUEST QUARTERS - LATE THAT NIGHT

Wren, alone, sits with the pendant in her palm, turning it over and over. A private, unguarded moment: no audience, nothing to prove.

WREN

(to herself, quiet,
frightened by the
question itself)

What if this is just me. What if I walked in here already looking for Derek's face on every wall, and I found it, because I always find it, because that's what the four years taught my eyes to do.

She looks at the pendant. Her reflection in its clouded glass doesn't answer. It's just her. Uncertain. Human. Possibly right. Possibly not. The film does not resolve this doubt for her, or for us, tonight.

She sets the pendant down and, for the first time since arriving, does not pick it back up right away.

END OF ACT TWO

ACT THREE

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - DRIVEWAY - DAWN

Wren, bag already in the trunk, sits in her car at the edge of the gravel, engine off, hands on the wheel. She's leaving. We believe it.

She looks back once at the house. A light is on in Ivy's window. Just one.

Long beat. Wren takes the keys out of the ignition.

WREN

(to no one)

Coward's exit doesn't count if
you leave the reason behind.

She gets out. Doesn't look back a second time; that would be too easy, too clean. She just goes back in, the decision costing her visibly, nothing triumphant about it.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - HIDDEN ARCHIVE ROOM - NIGHT

Jonah leads Wren through a door behind a library bookcase: the estate's real history, kept literally behind a wall. Old ledgers, four generations of "Founders," photographs yellowing in sequence.

WREN

You knew this was here the whole
time.

JONAH

Found it my first year. Never had
anyone to show it to who'd
believe me. Lucia wouldn't come
down here. Wouldn't even stand at
the door.

They scan shelves. Financial ledgers, first: unglamorous,
damning in a different way, decades of "donations" routed
through shell accounts, members' inheritances signed over
to Circle-affiliated trusts, a paper trail of grinding,
mundane greed that needs no ghost story to explain it.

WREN

This alone would put him away for
a decade. Fraud. Coercive
financial control. This is a case
Sheriff Reyes could actually
make.

JONAH

(grim)

Except it's the boring version.
Watch how fast a jury believes a
con man versus how fast anyone
believed you about Marguerite's
eyes.

A sound in the hall: footsteps, unhurried, close. They
freeze, kill the lantern. PIPER passes the gap under the
door, pauses a half-second too long, moves on. Whether she
heard anything is left open. She doesn't come in.

Wren exhales.

WREN

That was close.

JONAH

Everything here is close. That's
the design.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - HIDDEN ARCHIVE ROOM - NIGHT (TWO NIGHTS LATER)

Deeper in the shelves now. Wren finds the older ledger, the one from Act One's first pass, cross-generational, the hollow-oval symbol repeating beside certain names.

WREN

"Supply." Every generation has one, penciled in beside the founder's name like a job title.

JONAH

Every generation also has three or four "flying," penciled in smaller. I looked those up once. Members who did the group's dirty work and then just - vanished from the record after. Not dead, as far as I could ever find. Just gone. Unpersoned.

Wren finds Rosalind Cassidy's name, 1994. Beside it: SUPPLY - PRIMARY. TRANSFERRED.

WREN

(quiet, cold)

"Transferred." Not "left." Not "died."

She keeps flipping. Finds an older, brittle photograph: four founders across four generations, same eyes, same eerie stillness in every version, going back to a formal portrait dated 1911. The hollow-oval symbol overlays each face like a watermark.

JONAH

Every generation, one of them
"hosts" it, is what I think.
Feeds it, gets fed by it - power,
followers, whatever it wants that
decade. And it never runs out of
hungry rooms to move into.
Church, company, family, commune.
Doesn't matter the building. Just
needs the shape.

WREN

The shape being what, exactly?

JONAH

Somebody willing to be worshipped
instead of known. It'll take
almost anyone eventually, if
enough people keep clapping. Or -
if you want Okafor's version,
which some nights I do - it's
just what four generations of a
family with the same three ugly
traits, taught to each other like
a trade, looks like from outside
once you're primed to see a
monster in it.

WREN

You don't sound sure which one
you believe.

JONAH

I've had six years to decide.
I've got exactly as far as: it
doesn't matter which one's true.
Either way it eats the same
people the same amount.

WREN

I need someone who got out. Not a
ledger entry. A person I can look
at.

JONAH

(a long beat)

There's one. Grace Odom. Left four years ago, before my time here properly started, but the groundskeeper before me used to mention her like a ghost story. She runs the feed store off Route 9. I'll cover for you at lunch circle.

INT. HOLLOW CREEK - FEED STORE - DAY

Bags of grain stacked to the ceiling, the smell of hay and diesel. GRACE ODOM, early 40s, weighs out seed by hand rather than trusting the digital scale, the way someone trusts nothing fully anymore that isn't checked twice.

WREN

Jonah Price sent me. I'm not with them. My sister is.

Grace doesn't look up right away. When she does, it's with the specific, exhausted wariness of someone who has had this exact conversation before and regretted it more than once.

GRACE

Four years out and people still find me to ask if it was real. I've stopped being able to answer that helpfully. Some days I think Rafe Aurelio is the most ordinary kind of predator this country produces by the thousand, dressed up in incense. Other days I still can't explain why I couldn't make myself blink during my Unveiling, or why my little brother, five hundred miles away and never once inside those gates, called me sobbing that same night saying he'd had a nightmare about a mask with no eyes. Make of that what you will. I've given up making anything of it myself.

WREN

Did leaving help.

GRACE

(the most honest thing
anyone in this story
has said)

Leaving helped everything except the part of me that still checks mirrors twice before I trust what's in them. That part didn't leave when I did. I don't know if it ever fully does.

She hands Wren a folded newspaper clipping from a drawer without being asked: a decade-old missing-persons notice, a young woman's photo, case listed as inactive.

GRACE (CONT'D)

That's the one before Marguerite.
Before her, there's another. I
used to keep a list. Stopped when
the list got long enough to feel
like a haunting of its own. Get
your sister out, and don't wait
for proof that'll satisfy a
courtroom. By the time that proof
exists, it's usually because
somebody didn't make it out in
time to be believed.

Wren pockets the clipping. Whatever comfort she came here
for, this isn't it. It's worse, and truer, and exactly
what she needed instead.

INT. HOLLOW CREEK - SHERIFF'S OFFICE - DAY (LATER THAT
DAY)

Wren, back in Reyes's office, slides photographed ledger
pages and Grace's clipping across the desk: a date, a
name, a case number, exactly what he asked for last time.

REYES

(studying them longer
than he wants to
admit, the ease
draining out of his
posture)

Where'd you get bank records for
a private trust.

WREN

I didn't. That's a photograph of
a ledger sitting in a room behind
a bookcase on private property. I
know how that sounds.

REYES

(a long, unhappy
silence)

It sounds like something I can't
act on and can't quite put down
either. Give me the clipping. I
can run the missing-persons case
again as a cold-case review
without naming where the tip came
from. That much I can do quiet.

WREN

And the rest of it?

REYES

(honest, for the first
time, not proud of it)

The rest of it needs the state,
not me, and the state needs more
than a photograph of a ledger,
however bad it looks. I'm not
telling you to stop. I'm telling
you what a courtroom will and
won't hold, and I'd rather you
hear that from me now than find
it out too late to matter.

It isn't the rescue Wren wanted. It's the first crack of
daylight the outside world has shown all week, and she
takes it.

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - GROUNDS - NIGHT

Wren, walking back from the library, finds Marcus waiting
on the path, unhurried, blocking it without seeming to.

MARCUS

(pleasant, terrible)

Feed store's a nice drive this time of year. Grace Odom still weighing seed by hand, I take it. Nan Cassidy. Cottage at the edge of Hollow Creek. Widow, one daughter, deceased 2015, cause of death left interestingly vague on the county record. We knew who your mentor was before your car cleared the gate, and we knew where you went today before Jonah finished covering for you at lunch circle. Radical authenticity works both directions, Wren. We're just more honest about looking than you are.

WREN

(refusing to let the fear show, though it's real now)

Is that meant to scare me off, or just remind me you've been reading my mail.

MARCUS

It's meant to remind you that nothing you've found down there is a secret from us. It's only a secret from Reyes and the county, and only for as long as we decide it's useful to let it be. Keep digging if it helps you sleep. Just understand you're digging in a garden we planted the shovel in.

He steps aside, finally, letting her pass, the threat delivered, unhurried, already turning back toward the house like a man who has said exactly as much as he intended to and not one word more.

Wren doesn't run. She makes herself walk at the same pace all the way to her door. It costs her everything she has left that night.

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - GATES - DAY (THE NEXT MORNING)

A car idles at the gate. NAN, small against the wrought iron, stands at the intercom, refusing to leave. Marcus and a second Keeper block the drive on foot, pleasant, immovable.

MARCUS

(warm, terrible)

Mrs. Cassidy. We've explained twice now - unscheduled visits aren't part of the Circle's boundaries policy. You're welcome to write.

NAN

(not moving an inch)

I buried a daughter you people call "transferred" in your own paperwork. I'll stand at this gate as long as my knees allow it, and my knees have outlasted worse men than you.

Word reaches Wren fast. She runs the length of the drive, breath tearing, and reaches the gate just as Marcus is turning Nan's car away.

WREN

(breathless, to
Marcus)

Two minutes. Through the bars.
That's not against any policy
you've quoted me yet.

Marcus weighs it, decides it costs him nothing, steps back exactly two feet, close enough to hear every word.

NAN

(low, urgent, through
the iron)

I shouldn't have sent you in here
with nothing but a cracked mirror
and a hope. I've been sitting in
my kitchen for four days doing
the math on that mistake.

WREN

(steady, meaning it)

You didn't send me anywhere, Nan.
I got in the car myself. Ivy's
still in there and she's still
reachable. I need you to trust
that more than you trust your own
worst year.

Nan's composure, thirty years in the making, cracks for
exactly one visible second. Then she nods, once, hard, and
lets Marcus's presence win back the moment, because there
is nothing else here to win.

NAN

(already turning back
toward her car, not
looking back again)

Four days, Wren. Then I call
people who don't care about
anybody's boundaries policy.

She goes. Marcus watches her taillights all the way to the
bend in the road before he even looks at Wren again.

MARCUS

(mild, chilling)

Sweet, that you have someone
worrying. Most of the interesting
ones do.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - RAFE'S PRIVATE STUDY - NIGHT

Wren, unable to sleep, drawn by dread, watches through a cracked door as Rafe sits utterly alone before a full-length mirror. The performance is gone. His face, unwitnessed, sags into something ancient and starving. Not menacing exactly. Emptied. A man wearing his own face as a final, exhausted mask.

Behind the mirror's ornate frame, barely visible at this angle, a thin seam runs along one edge: old brass hardware, half-hidden by gilt. A door, or a panel, built into the frame itself. Wren doesn't see it. We do, just barely.

He notices the mirror's reflection catch a shadow. Whirls.

RAFE
(sharp, unguarded)
Who's -

He recovers instantly, warmth sliding back over his features like a visor snapping shut.

RAFE (CONT'D)
(smiling into the dark
hallway)
Can't sleep? Come in. I don't
bite. Well - not without an
invitation.

Wren, caught, steps into the doorway rather than flee. Strategic exposure beats a chase.

WREN
I saw your face just now. Before
you knew I was here.

RAFE

(a beat, genuinely
thrown, then
recovering with
practiced grace)

Everyone's tired at midnight,
Wren.

WREN

That wasn't tired. That was
empty.

Rafe studies her, something shifting behind his eyes:
recalculating. He crosses to her, closer than comfortable,
and for the first time, drops the sermon entirely.

RAFE

(quiet, almost
sincere)

You want to know a secret nobody
in that dining hall would
believe? I don't feel anything,
most days. Not really. Just an
itch that gets loud enough to be
mistaken for a feeling, and then
quiet again the second enough
people are looking at me. You
clock people, don't you. That's
your whole gift. Tell me - what
do you see when you look at me?

It's a trap dressed as vulnerability, and also,
unbearably, possibly half true. Wren can't tell which
half, and that's exactly what he's counting on.

WREN

(carefully, not
performing fear, not
performing pity)

I see a very hungry hollow
wearing a very good haircut. I
don't know yet if that's a
metaphor or a diagnosis.

A flicker: something in Rafe genuinely flinches, fast, gone. Then the smile returns, wider, delighted, dangerous.

RAFE

See, that. That's why I want you here. Selah loves easily and it makes her useless to me for the truth. You don't love easily. You'll tell me exactly what I am. Stay. Not as a guest. As - equal. My grandfather never had anyone who could see him clearly and choose to stay anyway. I think that's what actually cures the itch. Not worship. Witness.

For one full beat, she visibly considers it. Refusing costs her something real.

WREN

(quiet)

I already gave someone that exact kind of witnessing once. It didn't cure anything. It just taught me the shape of my own disappearing.

RAFE

(soft, almost gentle,
the mask cracking
sideways into
something worse)

Then you already know how good it feels right before you vanish.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - SELAH'S SITTING ROOM - NIGHT

An unexpected summons. Selah, alone, no rings of members, no ceremony, just two women and a pot of tea Wren doesn't touch.

SELAH

(unguarded, for the
first time, or
performing unguarded
so well it makes no
difference)

I watched you refuse to say his
name at the Radical Honesty
circle. Derek. You didn't say it
even under all that pressure.
I've never been able to do that.
Not once, not about Rafe, not in
fifteen years, and God knows I've
been asked in rooms far gentler
than the one we put you in.

WREN

(wary of the trap,
unsure yet if there is
one)

Why tell me that.

SELAH

Because I don't think you're
wrong about all of it. I think
you're wrong about the ratio. You
think it's mostly harm with a
little real love scattered in to
bait the trap. I think it's
mostly real (Theo, Doris, forty
other people who eat dinner
together and mean it) with
something genuinely rotten
sitting at the center that the
rest of us built the good part
around, the way you'd grow a
garden around a sinkhole because
moving is unthinkable.

WREN

That's not a defense, Selah.
That's a confession with better
landscaping.

SELAH

(a real, tired laugh,
the mask slipping just
slightly and both of
them registering it)

Maybe it is. I'm not offering it
as a defense. I'm offering it
because you're the first person
in a decade who's looked at me
like I might still be a person
underneath my own architecture,
and I find I don't hate the
feeling as much as I expected to.

She doesn't ask Wren to stay. Doesn't threaten her either.
It's the most dangerous conversation in the house
precisely because nothing in it is a lie.

WREN

(carefully, testing)

Leave with me. Tonight. Bring
Ivy. See what's true once
nobody's watching either of you.

SELAH

(the mask fully back
on, quick, final, and
something behind it
that might be grief)

I built this house, Wren. You
don't leave a house you built.
You just get better and better at
deciding which rooms in it you're
allowed to visit.

She stands, the audience over. But the seed is planted,
visibly, and will not be forgotten by either woman before
the chapel.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - IVY'S ROOM - DAY

Piper, "mentoring," adjusts the collar of Ivy's dress a
half-inch, unprompted, the correction so small and so
practiced it barely registers as a correction at all.

PIPER

Chin a little higher when he's in
the room. Not proud. Just -
available to be seen. It reads
better in photographs.

IVY

(already adjusting,
already grateful for
the instruction)

Like this?

PIPER

Perfect. You're a fast study.
Faster than I was.

IVY

Were you ever - considered. The
way I am now.

A long beat. Something in Piper closes like a hand.

PIPER

(flat, final,
protecting something
we don't yet
understand)

No. I wasn't primary material. I
was useful in other ways. That's
not a worse thing to be, Ivy.
It's just a different weight to
carry.

Ivy doesn't ask what "other ways" means. Piper doesn't
offer. Whatever happened to Piper at nineteen sits,
unspoken, in the exact shape of every instruction she now
hands down to someone younger with total, well-practiced
tenderness: the co-dependency sick cycle, one careful
adjustment of a collar at a time, passed hand to hand like
something being kept warm rather than kept alive.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - RAFE AND SELAH'S PRIVATE QUARTERS - NIGHT

No members. No ceremony. Just a marriage, or the machine that replaced one somewhere along the way. Rafe paces. Selah sits very still, watching him the way a keeper watches weather.

RAFE

She asked Ivy to look at the ledger page. Wren. She's teaching my primary candidate to read the accounting like it's a crime scene.

SELAH

(carefully neutral,
testing the ground)

Maybe it is one. You've never once let me ask that question out loud in fifteen years. I'm asking it now, quietly, just to you.

RAFE

(a flash of something
genuinely dangerous,
gone as fast as it
appears)

Don't. Not you. I need one person in this house who doesn't flinch when I forget which face I'm wearing.

SELAH

(the closest to naked
honesty we've seen
from her)

I've spent fifteen years being that person, Rafe, and I still don't know if you love me or just haven't gotten hungry enough yet to notice I'm the one thing left in easy reach.

He doesn't answer. That, itself, is the answer. Selah absorbs it the way she's absorbed every unanswered question in this house: by standing up, smoothing her dress, and preparing to hold the room together one more night, for reasons that stopped, a long time ago, having anything to do with belief.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - GUEST QUARTERS - HALLWAY - NIGHT

Wren, unable to sleep, walks the hall barefoot: no destination, just motion against the quiet. She passes an ornate mirror, gilt-framed, twin to the one in Rafe's study. She doesn't slow down enough to really look.

Three steps past it, she stops. Something in the reflection didn't match her pace.

She backs up. Looks again. Her reflection lands a half-step behind her now, catching up as she watches, then perfectly synced, then behind again: so subtle she could believe she imagined it, so consistent she can't quite convince herself she did.

Above the frame, in the shadow between the crown molding and the wall: the same small dark lens she's counted before, aimed this time not at a door, not at a path. At her.

She keeps walking. Doesn't run. Somewhere behind her, faint and mechanical, a servo motor finds a new angle and holds it.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - CIRCLE HALL - DAY (DAYS LATER)

A member Wren doesn't recognize, a young man named ELIAS, collapses mid-session, seizing, genuinely terrified faces around him. Selah is there in seconds, commanding, competent, magnificent in the crisis, the whole room reorganizing around her grief and skill.

By evening, the story has changed shape twice: Elias "processed something enormous," Elias is "resting," Elias is "not to be visited, for his own integration." The crisis becomes, within hours, a communal event: candles

lit for him in the dining hall, a fresh surge of gratitude and fear binding the room tighter than any sermon could.

Ivy, who had been quietly drifting toward Wren all week, is pulled entirely back into the current, assigned to "hold vigil," her guilt at ever doubting the Circle now fully, freshly re-armed.

IVY

(to Wren, urgent,
ashamed of her own
relief at having a
reason to retreat)

I can't talk right now. Elias
needs the room's energy clean. I
have to go be clean for him.

WREN

Ivy, that's not how bodies work,
that's not how any of this -

Ivy is already walking away as she says it.

IVY

You weren't here for the last
one. You don't get to have an
opinion on how we hold each
other.

Whether Elias's collapse was real, staged, or something in between is never confirmed. It doesn't need to be. The effect on the room is identical either way, and that, precisely, is the horror.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - LAUNDRY LINE - DUSK

Wren, hanging linens as part of her assigned chores, finds Piper already there, working in silence. For once, no one else is close enough to perform for.

WREN

You moved my seat away from Rafe on my first night. You've been protecting me a little this whole time, haven't you. Even while you were reporting on me.

PIPER

(not denying it, which is its own kind of answer)

Both things can be true in the same person. I'd have thought a sound healer would understand that better than most.

WREN

I do. I just want to know which one wins, when it matters.

PIPER

(a long silence, pinning a sheet with more focus than it requires)

Six years ago somebody could have handed nineteen-year-old me a key to something. Nobody did. I used to think that was because nobody cared enough. I've started thinking it's because by the time you're useful to this house, you've already stopped looking like someone worth the risk.

WREN

You still look like someone worth the risk to me.

Piper doesn't answer that directly. But something in her decision visibly finishes itself right there, in the quiet, over a basket of damp sheets: not a grand turn, just a small, private arithmetic resolving in Piper's favor for once.

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - SERVICE COURTYARD - DUSK

Wren, crossing toward the laundry room, passes a young member unloading crates, wood mask hanging from her belt the way Marguerite's silver one does now. Not yet named to us. Just a face, doing an ordinary chore.

For one unshielded second, unwatched, the member's eyes go somewhere Wren recognizes immediately. Not sad. Not tired. Vacant, in the specific, practiced way glass looks vacant.

A senior Keeper rounds the corner. The member's face reassembles, warm and present and apologetic for nothing at all, before Wren can even be sure of what she saw.

WREN

(to herself, quiet)

That's not Marguerite's face.
That's just Marguerite's face, on
somebody younger. There's more
than one.

She keeps walking. It costs her something to keep walking.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - KITCHEN GARDEN - NIGHT

Piper, tense, finds Wren alone, presses a small brass key into her hand fast, like passing contraband.

PIPER

Chapel's east door. Staff use
only. Don't tell me what you
find. Don't tell anyone I gave it
to you.

WREN

Piper -

PIPER

(already backing away)

I didn't do this. This didn't
happen.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - CIRCLE HALL - NIGHT (LATER)

A "correction": quieter, colder than the Radical Honesty ritual, no candles, no warmth. Piper stands alone in the center of a small circle of senior members, SELAH presiding.

SELAH

(gentle, devastating)

We don't punish here. We just notice when someone's stopped trusting the room enough to let it hold her secrets. That's not a crime, Piper. It's just information. About where you actually are.

Piper's wooden-to-bone mask is quietly, ceremonially exchanged for a plainer one, a visible demotion dressed as compassion. No one raises their voice. It is somehow worse than if they had.

Later, Wren, from a distance, watches Piper cross the lawn alone afterward, not crying, worse than crying: flat, compliant, already re-absorbing the lesson.

WREN

(to herself)

That's the cost of helping me. I need to remember that's the cost.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - LAUNDRY ROOM - DAY

Doris, folding linens, doesn't look up when Wren enters. Marcus passes the doorway once, twice, a slow patrol. Doris waits until his second pass is well clear.

DORIS

(low, brisk, no drama
in it at all)

Piper didn't give you that key so
you'd get caught with it in a
laundry room. Whatever you're
building toward, build it faster.
Marcus reports everything he sees
by Thursday supper. It's Tuesday.

WREN

(careful)

Why are you telling me this. You
said this place made you better.

DORIS

It did. That doesn't mean I think
it should get to keep your sister
to prove it worked on me. Ten
good years doesn't buy them your
family too. I'm not leaving,
Wren. I'm not your rescue story.
I'd just rather not be able to
say later that I watched and did
nothing.

She hands Wren a folded towel with something small and
hard rolled inside it: a spare fuse for the chapel's
east-door circuit, palmed from the utility shed.

DORIS (CONT'D)

In case that door decides to lock
itself behind you. It's done that
before. To other people.

She goes back to folding, unhurried, as if nothing passed
between them at all. Both things, the decade of genuine
peace and this quiet, deliberate act of resistance against
the place that gave it to her, are true of the same woman,
in the same breath.

Wren pockets the fuse, steps out into the yard. Above the
roofline, a single window she's never been shown lights,
briefly, then goes dark again, on cue, the instant she

looks up at it, as if the house noticed her noticing.

She doesn't go find out what room that was. Not tonight.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - GUEST QUARTERS - NIGHT

Wren, alone, notices for the first time: the "welcome tea" left nightly on her nightstand, untouched for days, is nearly empty in the pot despite her not remembering drinking most of it. A dawning, quiet unease.

She sets it aside. That night, for the first time, her vision swims at the edges: a shape in the corner of the room that resolves, when she turns to look, into nothing but a coat on a hook. She stares at the coat a beat too long anyway.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - CHAPEL - EAST DOOR - NIGHT

Wren uses Piper's key. Inside: a narrow service passage behind the altar wall. She finds, hidden in a recess, old but functioning audio equipment: subwoofers, a reel-to-reel cousin of her own machine at home, cabling running up toward the eave where she now recognizes the small dark lens from before as a camera housing.

This is proof of something. Just not proof of everything. The mundane explanation, staged infrasound, hidden recordings, theatrical machinery built by a showman's grandfather, sits here, solid and real.

And yet it does nothing to explain what Wren felt looking into Marguerite's eyes, and does nothing at all to explain the seam she half-glimpsed in Rafe's mirror frame, three rooms away, that this passage does not connect to.

She photographs it on her phone with shaking hands. On the third photo, the flash catches her own reflection in a polished brass fitting, and for one frame, too fast to be sure, her reflected eyes don't quite track with her own.

She lowers the phone. Doesn't look again tonight.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - IVY'S ROOM - NIGHT

Wren slips in one more time. Ivy, awake, sitting very still in the dark, mask, plain wood rising toward bone, on the nightstand beside her like a second face waiting its turn.

WREN

Ivy. Listen to me for one minute without deciding I'm the enemy.

IVY

(hollow, rehearsed)

Selah says doubt right before an Unveiling is the ego's last performance. That the discomfort means it's working.

WREN

Selah says a lot of things designed to make sure you never trust the discomfort that's trying to save your life.

IVY

(a real crack,
finally)

I don't feel saved, Wren. I feel like I'm disappearing and everyone keeps telling me that's what enlightenment feels like from the inside. How would I even know the difference?

WREN

(urgent, gentle)

Because I know the difference. I lived four years thinking my disappearing was intimacy. It took almost losing everything to learn the difference between being emptied and being met.

Ivy cries, real and unguarded, for the first time.

IVY

He said I'm being considered for something. Something important. Something only one person gets to be.

Wren pulls the ledger page she photographed from her pocket and shows it to Ivy directly for the first time.

WREN

It's not an honor, Ivy. It's a job title. Marguerite had it for six years. Look what it says next to her name now.

Ivy reads: SUPPLY - PRIMARY. Beside a newer line, ink barely dry: NEXT PRIMARY SUPPLY (PENDING): I. MERCER.

Ivy goes white, the page shaking in her own hands now, not Wren's.

IVY

(barely audible)

That's my initial.

WREN

That's not a coincidence and it's not an accident. He's not choosing you because you're special, Ivy. He's choosing you because you're next in a line that goes back to before either of us was born.

IVY

(standing, suddenly, decisive in a way we haven't seen from her yet)

Then we go. Right now. Both of us. Out the service road, past the orchard, before anyone's doing rounds.

She's already pulling a coat on. Wren, startled by the speed of it, grabs her own bag. For a few seconds, escape is simply a plan two sisters are executing, nothing more dramatic than that: shoes, a door, a dark road.

WREN

(quiet, hopeful,
almost disbelieving)

Okay. Okay. Yes. Let's go.

The door opens. LUCIA, warm, oblivious, mid-sentence before she even sees the page in Ivy's hands, one shoulder already in the doorway they needed clear.

LUCIA

Ivy, I brought you -

She stops. Sees the page. Sees Ivy's face. Sees, with dawning, innocent horror, exactly what it means that a guest is showing a member confidential ledger pages in the middle of the night.

LUCIA (CONT'D)

(genuinely frightened,
genuinely trying to
help - herself)

Ivy, you shouldn't be looking at
Founders' records, that's -
that's a boundary violation, that
could hurt your integration, I
have to -

IVY

(desperate)

Lucia, don't -

Lucia is already backing out, already deciding, entirely certain she's protecting her friend.

LUCIA

I'm sorry. I have to tell Selah.
It's for your own good. You'll
understand later, I promise,
everyone does.

She's gone. Not a villain. A true believer, doing exactly what three years of gentle, total conditioning taught her was love.

WREN

(quiet, devastated)

She's not lying to hurt you.

IVY

(hollowed out)

I know. That's what makes it so much worse.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - HALLWAY OUTSIDE IVY'S ROOM -
CONTINUOUS

Wren and Ivy move fast, too late. The hallway ahead is already filling, not a mob, worse: a calm, sorrowful procession, SELAH at its head, RAFE a step behind her, PIPER among them now back in her demoted mask, JONAH nowhere in sight, LUCIA hanging back near the rear, hand pressed to her mouth, already regretting it and already certain she was right to do it, both at once.

SELAH

(so gentle it's
obscene)

Wren. We were hoping tonight
wouldn't have to look like this.

WREN

(placing herself
between Selah and Ivy)

It doesn't have to. Let us walk
to my car. Both of us. Right now.

RAFE

(sorrowful,
magnificent, utterly
in command)

See, this is the tragedy of it.
She still thinks this is a
hostage situation. Ivy -
sweetheart - tell your sister
nobody here has ever stopped her
leaving.

IVY

(torn apart, unable to
say the easy lie,
unable to say the hard
truth)

Wren, just - come with me to the
chapel. Talk to Rafe there.
Please. It's the only way this
doesn't get worse for both of us.

Wren knows exactly how this gets worse for both of them.
She goes anyway. There's no version of tonight that
doesn't.

A member behind Wren presses a damp cloth-wrapped hand
briefly to the back of her neck under the guise of a
comforting touch, too fast to register as anything but
affection. The corridor tilts, gently, at the edges.

WREN

(swaying, fighting it)

What did you -

SELAH

(already taking her
arm, solicitous,
terrible)

Just something to help you be
present. You've been so tense all
week. Let us hold you now.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - CHAPEL - RITUAL CHAMBER - NIGHT
(CONTINUOUS)

Wren is walked, more carried than walked, into the ritual chamber: candlelight swimming, the concentric rings of masked members already assembling with the eerie speed of a rehearsed thing. The tall, cloudy mirror waits at the center, exactly as we glimpsed it never being shown to her before tonight.

Ivy is pulled into the outer ring, masked, before she can reach her sister. Piper's new, plainer mask goes on last, her eyes the only unmasked thing in the room, unreadable.

Wren's last clear thought before the drug and the candlelight blur together:

WREN (CONT'D)
(barely a whisper)
Nan. I don't know which one's
true. I don't know if I'm ready
either way.

The concentric hum begins: low, wordless, dozens of throats as one instrument.

SMASH CUT TO BLACK.

END OF ACT THREE

ACT FOUR

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - CHAPEL - RITUAL CHAMBER - NIGHT

Wren surfaces slowly, drugged, the candlelight smeared at its edges.

Concentric rings of masked members, humming a single low tone, packed close enough now that there's no clear path to a door. Wren, unmasked, kneels before the tall mirror, its surface the same cloudy quality as Nan's pendant, but vast, framed in old brass gone black with candle-smoke.

Selah stands at the mirror's edge like a priestess, ash still marking her forehead from the rite two nights ago. Rafe watches from a raised chair at the room's rear, gold mask now worn, expression unreadable behind it.

SELAH

(to the room,
ceremonial)

Every mask we wear was given to
us by someone who needed us small
enough to carry. Tonight, we
return the favor to our newest
sister. We help her see beneath
her own.

WREN

(steady, fighting the
drug, refusing the
script)

I already know what's beneath
mine, Selah. Do you know what's
beneath yours?

A ripple through the room. This isn't how it's supposed to go. Selah's serenity flexes, just slightly.

SELAH

(recovering, smooth)

Look in the mirror, Wren. Just
look.

Wren looks.

Her reflection doesn't move with her. It tilts its head, independent, curious, and behind its eyes, nothing. Not evil exactly. Absence. Dead-eyed darkness, patient as geology. THE HOLLOW, wearing her own face back at her.

Not Selah's voice, not Rafe's: genderless, ancient, intimate, coming from everywhere and nowhere, and also, unmistakably, routed through the hidden subwoofers Wren found three nights ago. Both things are true at once.

THE HOLLOW (V.O.)

There you are. I've been in this
room since before it had walls.
Since the womb, some of you.
Since the very first cycle. I
don't need you to love me. I only
need you to keep looking.

The candle flames along the altar bend toward the mirror, all of them, at once, against every draft in the room. Members sway. Ivy, masked now, sways with them, eyes glassy.

Wren, still half under the drug, reaches for the only tool Nan ever gave her, not the pendant, that's in her coat, out of reach. The lore itself.

WREN

(shaking, reciting,
half-remembered)

Fear feeds you. Shame feeds you.
An audience feeds you. I refuse
all three. I refuse -

The hum gets LOUDER. The mirror's surface RIPPLES, widening rather than cracking, the glass losing its edges. Rafe, behind his gold mask, grows, taller in his chair, more certain, feeding on the very act of her naming him.

THE HOLLOW (V.O.) (CONT'D)

(almost amused)

Oh - you brought a technique.
Everyone brings a technique
eventually. Your friend's mother
tried the same recitation, near
enough, in 1994. Ask her how that
went.

FLASH - the mirror fills, for three fast frames, with faces that aren't Wren's: a woman in 1950s dress, mid-scream, no sound reaching her; a man in a high collar, decades older, arms raised to a crowd not in this room; RAFE'S OWN FACE, four generations deep, each version standing a half-step behind the last, all looking out through the glass at the same hungry audience across a hundred years.

The vision breaks as fast as it came. Around the ring, other members flinch too, at something, though not necessarily the same something.

FLASH - a fast, visceral memory: Derek's hand, a door, a version of Wren smaller than she is now, apologizing for existing.

Wren's reflection in the mirror smiles without her: the shape of Derek's smile, borrowed, mocking.

Marcus steps in close behind her, a hand closing hard on her shoulder, no longer gentle, holding her in place before the glass.

MARCUS

(quiet, only to her)

Stay in the ring. It goes easier
the less you fight the shape of
it.

And then - not a technique. Not a recitation. A choice, made in real time, with no guarantee attached to it at all.

Wren drives her elbow back, hard, into Marcus's ribs. He grunts, grip loosening for exactly long enough. She turns her whole body away from the mirror: the opposite of the room's entire architecture, which has trained every eye in it to face inward, toward the glass, toward the self offered up for consumption.

WREN

(to Ivy, not to the mirror, not to the room, just to her sister, quiet, no technique in it at all)

Ivy. I don't know if I can fix this. I don't know if anything I say tonight works. I just know I'm not going to spend whatever's left of it talking to a mirror instead of you.

Ivy's glassy eyes flicker. Fight, for the first time, through the fog toward an actual voice instead of the room's hum.

Rafe rises, gold mask, his voice amplified by the room's own design.

RAFE

(a performance of command, the reflex firing hard now that something's genuinely slipping)

She's disrupting the Unveiling. This is exactly the kind of outside contamination we -

Marcus lunges for Wren again. She twists free, putting the stone altar between them, candle wax scattering, one flame

catching the hem of her sleeve, small, smothered fast against her own forearm. She doesn't flinch. There isn't time to.

She doesn't raise her voice to match Rafe. The opposite: unbearably calm, unafraid for the first time tonight of being wrong.

WREN

Rafe. I don't actually know what you are. Man, pattern, or something older wearing both. I've stopped needing to know tonight, same as Nan stopped needing to know thirty years ago. Take off the gold one anyway. Just once. Let this room see what it's actually been kneeling to, whatever that turns out to be.

Silence. Genuine silence: the room has never seen anyone ask this without flinching first. Selah's serenity finally, visibly cracks.

SELAH

(too fast, too sharp)
That is not how this works -

WREN

(gently,
devastatingly, to
Selah)

No. I imagine it's never worked that way for you either. How long have you been building him a room to be worshipped in so you'd never have to look in your own mirror, Selah?

Selah's composure shatters, not into rage, into something far more dangerous: recognition.

Under the voice, faintly, for one frame only: the mechanical whine of an overdriven subwoofer struggling to

keep pace.

THE HOLLOW (V.O.)

(straining now, less
certain for the first
time)

Stop that. Stop LOOKING at it
like that.

WREN

(to the mirror, to the
room, to all of it,
steady)

I see it. All of it. The mask,
the hunger, the fifty years of
borrowed faces. And I'm not
scared of it, and I'm not ashamed
of what it already took from me.
You don't get to eat what I've
already forgiven myself for
surviving.

The mirror's surface RIPPLES again, harder: a jagged crack
forks corner to corner. The Hollow's borrowed reflection
loses its grip on Wren's face entirely, snapping back to
just Wren, tired, whole, unmasked, present.

One by one, around the room, wooden masks slip, not torn
off, simply loosen, as members blink awake mid-sway,
confused, ashamed, human again. Ivy's mask falls from her
face and she GASPS like surfacing from deep water, knees
buckling.

Wren shoves past two swaying members who don't resist,
crosses the ring in four strides, and catches Ivy before
she hits the stone floor. She holds her sister upright by
main force, not ceremony, Ivy's full weight sagging into
her.

WREN (CONT'D)
(low, only to Ivy, no
room left to perform
for anyone else)
I've got you. Stand up in one
second. Not yet. I've got you.

Marcus, mask still on, stares down at his own hands like
he doesn't recognize them.

Rafe, exposed under the room's sudden, unraveling
attention, staggers slightly, the performance faltering
with nothing left to feed it.

Piper, still masked, doesn't move. We don't know yet which
way she'll break.

END OF ACT FOUR

ACT FIVE

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - CHAPEL - CONTINUOUS

The hum has stopped. Members stand blinking in the sudden quiet, masks in their hands like objects they can't remember picking up. Some weep. Some flee the room outright. Piper, still masked, hasn't moved.

Gold mask still on, voice cracking, and for one dangerous beat, the old reflex very nearly works again.

RAFE

This is - she's manipulating the room, this is exactly the kind of instability I warned you all -
Selah, back me up, tell them what instability looks like -

For one terrible second, a few members' heads turn back toward him, old grooves reasserting themselves. Wren doesn't move. Doesn't speak. Doesn't hand him the room back.

SELAH

Nobody's looking at you, Rafe.
Nobody's looking at you and it's the first time in fifteen years I've let myself notice how quiet that actually is.

She takes off her own mask, the one nobody in the hierarchy ever handed her: her own composure, worn fifteen years, and now that's gone too. She looks, suddenly, very old and very tired.

Rafe lunges, not violence exactly, worse: he grabs for Ivy's wrist, the last piece of leverage in the room, an old animal reflex toward whatever's still willing to be held.

RAFE

(low, only to Ivy, the
mask entirely gone)

You were going to be the one who
stayed. You were going to be the
one who actually saw me and
didn't run.

Ivy pulls free, shaking, and answers in her own voice,
finally, entirely her own.

IVY

I did see you. That's exactly why
I'm leaving.

He doesn't chase her. Whatever was driving him, man,
pattern, or the older thing Nan never named for certain,
has nothing left in the room willing to feed it, and it
simply, visibly, runs out of road.

He doesn't die. Doesn't transform. Doesn't confess to
anything supernatural or admit to anything staged. He just
sits down, hard, on the chapel floor, a middle-aged man in
a gold mask that no longer means anything, in a room that
has stopped, all at once, agreeing to be afraid of him.

RAFE (CONT'D)

(quiet, to Wren,
almost pleading)

Without this, what am I.

WREN

(not cruel, just true)

I don't know. I think that's the
first honest question you've
asked all night. Maybe start
there. I'm not going to be the
one who answers it for you.

She doesn't kill it. Doesn't banish it in fire and violence, the way the genre trained us to expect. Whatever it was, it doesn't die because something has to die at the climax. It simply has nothing left to eat.

Whatever left him didn't leave because he earned it. Nan could have told her that part too, in a kitchen that smelled of dried sage.

It was never a morality tale. It doesn't reward the men who deserve better. It only ever checks whether the room's still watching. The day it isn't, it goes: not cured, not sorry, just hollowed out, already looking for a fuller room.

That threat is never fully closed. Nobody in this room, least of all Wren, pretends otherwise.

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - GROUNDS - DAWN

Members scatter in twos and threes across the lawn, disoriented, some already calling family, some standing frozen, grieving a version of belonging that was real to them even if it was built on sand. Theo holds Lucia, both of them crying for reasons that may not be the same reason.

Piper finds Wren near the gates, mask finally off, held loosely in one hand like something she hasn't decided whether to keep.

PIPER

(rough, unpracticed
honesty)

I believed all of it. Even the
parts I helped do to other
people. I don't know what that
makes me.

WREN

It makes you someone who got fed
a very good lie by someone very
practiced at it. That's not the
same as being one of them. What
you do starting now belongs to
nobody but you.

Piper doesn't have an answer yet. That's honest too. She
nods, walks off into the grey morning, unresolved.

INT. AURELIA ESTATE - MAIN HOUSE - DAY

Sirens, distant, arriving. Jonah, phone still in hand, has
finally made the calls that matter: the county line, a
state hotline, and a name that gets Sheriff Reyes moving
at last. The financial ledger, photographed page by page,
faxed to a friend at the state attorney's office before
anyone here could burn it.

The boring evidence, in the end, is the evidence that
holds up in a courtroom that was never going to take a
word about mirrors.

Rafe sits alone on the porch steps, unmasked, watching
authorities arrive, smaller with every passing minute.
Selah stands apart from him now, for the first time in
fifteen years, an unbridgeable few feet of gravel between
them.

MONTAGE - THE NETWORK, ELSEWHERE (INTERCUT)

- The Meridian Circle, two states over: their leader reads
the news off her phone at the head of a breakfast table
full of members, face unreadable, then sets the phone down
and keeps eating, the meal continuing exactly as it was.

- A different sister circle takes its public sun-and-mask
logo off its website within the hour, replacing it with a
soft-focus photo of a forest and the word "PAUSE."

- A third posts a long, warm statement about "holding
space for a sister community's growth journey" that
manages, in four hundred words, to defend everything

without naming anything.

Nine houses. One scandal reaches exactly as far as the county line drawn around this one estate, and not one inch further. The film does not pretend otherwise.

END MONTAGE.

EXT. AURELIA ESTATE - GATES - DAY

Wren and Ivy walk out together, unhurried, sunlight instead of string lights. Ivy leans into her sister's shoulder, exhausted, present.

IVY

I'm going to feel stupid about this for a long time.

WREN

You're going to feel a lot of things for a long time. Stupid's not the truest one. You loved something that was built to be loved. That's not stupidity. That's just the trap working exactly as designed.

IVY

How do I know, next time. How do I ever trust it again.

WREN

(plainly, no sermon in it)

You look for whether it can survive you seeing it clearly. Real love gets more solid the more clearly you see it. Everything else gets angry, or sad, or vanishes, the second the mask slips.

IVY

And the other thing. The thing in
the mirror. Was that even real?

WREN

(a long beat, the most
honest answer she has)

I don't know, Ivy. I felt
something in that room I can't
fully explain with wires and
drugged tea, and I found wires
and drugged tea that explain most
of what I felt. I've stopped
needing it to be only one of
those things. I'd rather walk
away uncertain than walk away
lying to myself about being
certain. That's the whole lesson,
if there is one.

INT. NAN'S COTTAGE - DAY (WEEKS LATER)

Wren sits with Nan again, tea between them, the pendant
back in Nan's palm now, its crack no darker, no lighter.

NAN

You didn't fight it. And your
little recitation didn't work
either, from what you told me on
the phone.

WREN

No. It made things worse for
about ninety seconds. I want you
to know that, in case anyone ever
asks you for the technique again.
Tell them it failed for me first.

NAN

(a real, rueful laugh)

That may be the most useful thing
anyone's told me in thirty years.
I've been handing out a cure I
was never sure was a cure. Good.
Maybe I'll finally stop.

WREN

(quiet)

I found Rosalind's name in their
ledger. "Transferred," not gone.
I don't know if that's comfort or
a new kind of grief.

Nan takes this in, a long silence, thirty years finally,
imperfectly, exhaling.

NAN

Both, probably. Most true things
are both.

She reaches over, closes her weathered hand over Wren's.

NAN (CONT'D)

You did something I couldn't, all
those years ago. Not because you
had the right answer. Because you
were willing to stand there
without one and stay honest
anyway. That's not a technique,
Wren. Techniques are what we
invent afterward so it sounds
like we knew what we were doing.
Somebody should be teaching the
actual thing, not just surviving
it in a garage with a tuning
fork.

A small, real smile: the first fully unguarded one we've
seen from her.

WREN

Funny you should say that.

INT. WREN'S SOUND STUDIO - DAY (LATER)

Same room as the opening. New client this time: a young woman, guarded, arms crossed, sitting exactly where Dale sat. On the wall behind Wren, new index cards have joined the old ones: FLYING MONKEYS. DARVO. COMMUNAL VALIDATION. SUPPLY.

And one new card, in different handwriting, Ivy's, added to the wall herself: ALCHEMY ISN'T ABOUT NOT SEEING THE DARK. IT'S ABOUT NOT BECOMING IT TO SURVIVE IT.

NEW CLIENT

I don't even know why I'm here.
Everyone says I'm being dramatic.

Wren answers with the exact line she opened the film on, only offered now, not performed.

WREN

You don't have to perform "fine"
in here. That's the one place
you're allowed to skip.

She strikes the tuning fork. Holds it up. The client exhales: the exact same ragged, involuntary sound Dale made, a hundred sessions ago and one lifetime of growth later.

Wren reaches past the new client and turns the DEREK index card face-down on the wall for the first time in the whole film. Small. Unremarked on. Everything.

Her reflection, briefly caught in the studio's window glass behind her, is simply, entirely her own.

She almost believes that's the end of it.

INT. HOLLOW CREEK - COUNCILWOMAN DIAZ'S OFFICE - DAY (SAME AFTERNOON)

Brief. Cold. A new plaque already ordered for the wall, a new "Community Partnership" folder open on the desk: a different name this time, a different logo, a sun without a mask now, which somehow isn't better.

Councilwoman Diaz, on the phone, warm, practiced, already rehearsing the tone she'll use at the next ribbon-cutting.

COUNCILWOMAN DIAZ

(into the phone,
pleasant, untroubled)

No, no, we're thrilled to have
you looking at the old estate.
Fresh energy is exactly what this
town needs after everything. When
can we schedule the walkthrough?

She hangs up. For one frame, alone, unwatched, her face goes still: present but absent, the eyes not quite tracking, gone as fast as it came.

She checks her lipstick in a small hand mirror, finds nothing wrong. Behind her own reflection, for exactly as long as it takes to blink, the glass holds a second shape too, patient, comfortable, already at home in a fuller room.

She goes back to her paperwork.

FADE OUT.

THE END